command and a separate senior commander oversaw terrorist operations carried out against India. Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi was Lashkar's operational commander and responsible for all of its military activities. Until his arrest in the wake of the 2008 Mumbai attacks, Lakhvi operated primarily from Pakistan-administered Kashmir, from where he supervised training for recruits as well.[1] Hafiz Saeed was the amir of MDI, and in this capacity he also oversaw those militant activities carried out under Lashkar's banner. Saeed installed some of his relatives in top positions to ensure an added layer of control. Lashkar gained a deserved reputation during the 1990s as one of the most organized and disciplined jihadi groups. However, as is often the case, competition and personal rivalries existed, and some senior commanders were more apt to obey orders or inspired more loyalty from their men than others.

The group began seriously building its domestic infrastructure around 1994, a time when state support was increasing significantly. By the turn of the century it operated more than seventy district offices and a plethora of smaller ones. Its departments included: the Department of Construction of Masajid [the plural of Masjid, which means mosque] and Madaris; the Department of Dawa; the Department of Education; the Department of External Affairs; the Department of Finance; the Department of Media and Propagation; the Dar al-Andalus Department of Publishing; the Department of Social Welfare; the Doctors' Wing; the Farmers' and Workers' Wing; the Students' Wing; the Teachers' Wing; and the Women's Wing.[2] All of these departments technically came under the MDI umbrella.

Zafar Iqbal, who taught with Saeed at the University of Engineering and Technology and was another of the original MDI founders, oversaw the Departments of Education and Social Welfare. He also managed the Teachers' and Doctors' Wings that were respectively part of these departments. The Department of Education was the group's most profitable and powerful department, and contributed manpower for the organization. Many of those who passed through its schools went on to work in a non-martial capacity for MDI in Pakistan.[3] Iqbal had co-founded the Jamaat-ul-Dawa missionary group in 1985 with Saeed and saw himself as Saeed's equal. The decision that Saeed would head MDI after it was launched in 1986 therefore created some tension.[4] In 1999 Iqbal challenged Saeed's authority, accusing him of nepotism and campaigning to have him removed